PREGABALIN

Misuse potential

Respiratory depression with opioids

CHEMICAL NAME (3S)-3-(aminomethyl)-5-methylhexanoic acid
CLASS Gabapentinoid (neuropathic analgesic, antiepileptic, anxiolytic)
TRADE NAMES Lyrica · Alzain · Axalid

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Neuropathic pain (peripheral and central).
- Generalised anxiety disorder.
- Focal seizures (adjunct).
- Fibromyalgia (some countries).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** twice (or three times) daily, with or without food.
- Titrate weekly; taper over ≥1 week when stopping.

DOSAGES

- **Neuropathic pain:** 75 mg twice daily, increase to 150 mg BD after 3–7 days; max 300 mg BD.
- **GAD:** 150 mg/day in 2–3 doses, up to 600 mg/day.
- **Renal impairment:** CrCl 30–60: 75–300 mg/day; 15–30: 25–150 mg/day; <15: 25–75 mg/day.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 1 h. Bioavailability ≥90% (linear, unlike gabapentin).
- Not metabolised.
- Excreted unchanged in urine. **t½:** 6 h.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Binds **α2δ subunit** of voltage-gated calcium channels → ↓ excitatory neurotransmitter release; more potent than gabapentin.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Dizziness, somnolence.
- Weight gain, peripheral oedema.
- Blurred vision, dry mouth, euphoria.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Respiratory depression with opioids/CNS depressants.
- Dependence, misuse, withdrawal (insomnia, anxiety, seizures).
- Angioedema; heart failure exacerbation.
- Suicidal ideation.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Hypersensitivity.
- **Caution:** renal impairment, heart failure, history of drug misuse.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Opioids, benzodiazepines, alcohol:** additive depression.
- **ACE inhibitors:** ↑ angioedema risk.
- **Pioglitazone:** ↑ oedema.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Renal dose adjustment.
- Assess sedation, falls, respiratory status.
- Monitor for misuse (early requests, dose escalation).
- Monitor weight, oedema.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Do not drive if dizzy or drowsy; avoid alcohol.
- Do not stop suddenly.
- Report swelling of face/lips, breathing difficulty.
- Keep medicine safely; risk of misuse.

KEY POINTS

- α2δ ligand, more potent than gabapentin.
- Renal dosing; weight gain, oedema.
- Pain, anxiety, seizures.
- Misuse; respiratory depression with opioids.